

When attention is not enough: how TikTok sells the TikTok audience

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From attention to engagement economies

Broadcast era attention capture by an industry skilled at “grabbing attention” (Williams 1974) and producing mass audiences for advertisers (Smythe 1981, Ang 1996).



Internet and Platform convergence of tracking and personalisation technologies, merging audience reach with clicks (Turow 2012, Webster 2014, Mellet and Beauvisage 2020).



Engagement economy where translation from attention into direct consumer action on-platform becomes paramount commercially (Ørmen & Gregersen 2022, Su 2023).



Tensions within the larger online attention economy

- Online advertising has long faced a **trust crisis** over viewability and effectiveness of its products (Cluley 2018; Hwang 2020).
- **Walled-garden platforms** – Meta, Google, TikTok, etc. – claim privileged access to 'real' attention (McGowan et al. 2024).
- In this context, these platforms actively **manage supply chains**, operating not just as intermediaries (Caliskan et al. 2025).

TikTok as a strategic case

- Relative newcomer needing to **establish legitimacy** with advertisers.
- ByteDance's ambition: become a **global e-commerce destination** (Su 2023).
- **Expanding infrastructure** for content production (Mahetaji and Nieborg 2025)
- How does TikTok **discursively sell** its audience and platform to advertisers?

Analytical Lens

Looking at **valuation practices** (Lamont 2012) through market **information regimes** (Anand and Peterson 2000) as sites where value is negotiated between platforms and partners.



Studying TikTok's market positioning



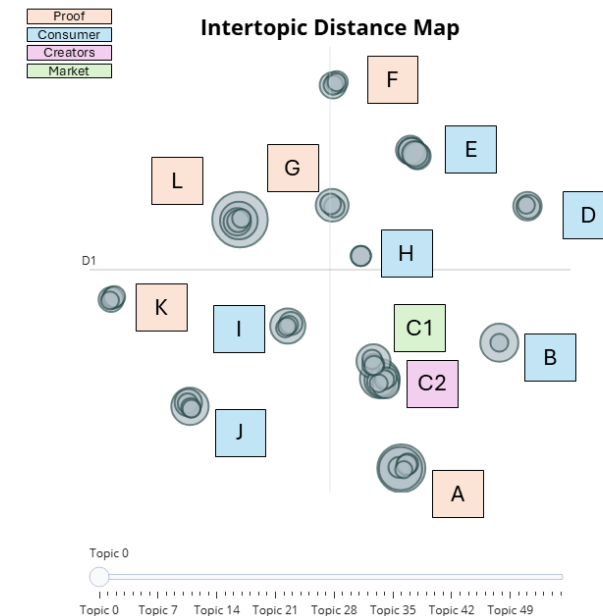
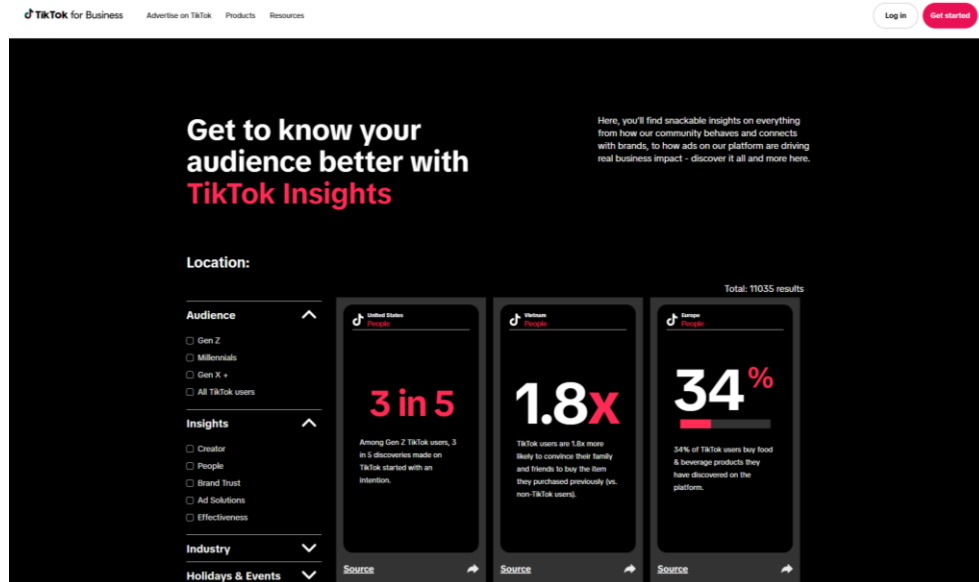
Corpus

1641 promotional statements scraped from TikTok for Business 'Insights' interface (Global filter, 30.03.2025).



Analysis

BERTopic modelling + qualitative thematic analysis; 61 topics → 12 clusters → 4 themes.



Market information based on third-party authority

- **No proprietary platform data** underpinning claims — almost entirely survey-based.
- Material+ alone supplies **77% of statements**; Nielsen, Kantar, Ipsos, Neurons also cited.
- TikTok borrows the **legitimacy of legacy market research** to address advertisers.

1641

Statements

25

From studies

77%

Attributed to one consultancy (Material+)

TikTok proves effectiveness, not just reach

- **580 statements** frame TikTok ads as causally effective.
- Cause–effect grammar dominates: 'After watching... X% more likely to...'.
- Includes **educational guidance** — how to make ads work on TikTok.



"After watching TikTok Creator Spark Ads, 62% of Gen Z TikTok users agree the Creator would be a natural fit to work with the brand."

— TikTok for Business insight

The TikTok user is rendered as ideal consumer

- **682 statements** construct audiences as active, engaged shoppers.
- Segmented by **generational cohorts** (Gen Z, Millennials, Gen X) and **consumer journeys**.
- Platform reframed as a **retail infrastructure**, not just a media space.



"1 in 2 Gen X weekly TikTok users agreed they'd feel safe providing their payment details through TikTok in-feed shopping ads."

— TikTok for Business insight

Creators sold as a catalytic force

- **189 statements** position TikTok Creators as a unique value proposition.
- Creators boost **believability**, community feeling, and conversion.
- Sold as something that '**does not exist elsewhere**' on the internet.



"1 in 2 Millennial TikTok users agree that watching Creator content on TikTok makes them feel like part of the brand's community."

— TikTok for Business insight

Positioning TikTok as unavoidable in the media mix

- **190 statements** make outward, comparative claims against rival platforms.
- Competition framed only against **other digital platforms** — not legacy media.
- Even **adding** TikTok to the mix is claimed to lift campaign performance.



"Pairing TikTok and other video platforms in the media mix makes Millennial users 1.2x more likely to stop and pay attention (vs. pairing other video with other platforms)."

— TikTok for Business insight

A tension between old and new valuation logics

Legacy logics deployed

Survey panels, generational cohorts, consumer-journey frameworks.

Platform novelty foregrounded

Creator culture, in-feed shopping, trend-driven discovery features.

Audience as commodity

Re-inscribed via 'old' social strata to remain legible to advertisers.

Audience as consumer subject

Reframed as active shopper translating attention into action.

Promotional discourse as a script for the future

- **What is absent** from the discourse: personalisation, algorithms, attention.
- Data and attention are implied to hold **value only when mobilised** through platform features, ad products, and creator labour.
- This discourse and claims advanced reveal **aspiration**, not yet a finalized social fact among advertisers or platform infrastructure.
- TikTok performs **legibility** to demand-side actors with pre-digital valuation norms. Information regimes open **spaces of negotiation** (Poell et al. 2023).

✓ Conclusions

- TikTok sells **engagement and consumer action**, not just attention.
- It builds credibility by borrowing **legacy market research authority**.
- Platforms exercise power by **managing supply chains** of audiences, creators, and brands.
- Future work could foreground **valuation** more and how supply chain dynamics are orchestrated around platforms.

Thank you

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